Galatians 1

Rescued by grace · Learning to receive

THE LETTER AT A GLANCE

Paul writes to churches in Galatia facing a question that reaches into our lives: Is Christ's saving work sufficient, or must we add something to be accepted by God? Chapters 1–2: the gospel received and defended. Chapters 3–4: faith, promise, law, and inheritance. Chapters 5–6: freedom, the Spirit, and life together. God's law is not the enemy; Paul challenges added requirements as the basis of our standing before God.

SCRIPTURE

Open your Bibles to **Galatians 1:1–24**. Galatians is a letter: Paul is making a case to churches he loves, so follow his reasoning. Chapter 1 moves from a greeting centered on Jesus (1:1–5), to Paul's alarm at a different gospel (1:6–10), to his own story of being called by grace (1:11–24). Watch for *grace*, *gospel*, and *called*.

Part 1 · Rescued, Not Self-Made

Galatians 1:1–10

Paul begins with God's action. Jesus "gave himself for our sins to rescue us from this present evil age" (1:4). A man who needs rescue cannot remove the danger by building a better record. Christ acts on our behalf, and God receives the glory. So Paul is alarmed that the churches are turning to a different gospel. Adding a condition to Christ's work, even a good one, changes the foundation we stand on. Responsible work, dependability, and spiritual discipline are good, but they cannot do the saving work that belongs to Christ. And Paul refuses to bend the gospel to please people (1:10). Because our hope rests in Christ, we can admit need and receive help without making self-sufficiency the measure of our worth.

DISCUSS

1. How would you explain the gospel to someone who asked what you believe? Where does Jesus' action in 1:3–5 appear in your explanation?
2. Where could an extra requirement, like always being dependable, appearing spiritually strong, or having a record you can be proud of, become the basis of your confidence before God?

Part 2 · Called by Grace

Galatians 1:11–24

Paul's gospel did not come from human approval. It came by a revelation of Jesus Christ (1:12). His former life proves it. He advanced beyond many of his peers and was extremely zealous for the traditions of his ancestors, and all that drive was aimed against God's church. Achievement did not earn his call. God set him apart, "called me by his grace," and was pleased to reveal his Son in him (1:15–16).

The story ends in an unexpected place. The churches in Judea kept hearing that their former persecutor now preached the faith he once tried to destroy, "and they glorified God because of me" (1:24). Paul's testimony doesn't make him look impressive. It makes God look gracious.

A man's record, good or bad, is not the deepest thing about him. Grace is. That frees us to tell our stories honestly and to give God the glory.

DISCUSS

1. Paul's zeal and achievement were aimed against Christ (1:13–14). How can drive and accomplishment become a way of standing apart from grace?
2. In 1:24 the churches glorified God because of Paul. How could your story, told honestly, point a brother to God's grace rather than to you?

REFLECTIONS

1. When do you find yourself presenting your record as the reason God should accept you?
2. Who is one brother you could ask for prayer or help with a faithful next step this week?

CLOSE PRAYER

Father, thank you for your grace through Jesus, who gave himself for our sins to rescue us. We bring you our pride, our failures, and our attempts to make ourselves secure. Teach us to receive Christ's rescue, to tell our stories for your glory, and to receive help from one another. Keep our confidence in Jesus. Amen.

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